BEYOND THE LEMON GROVE

The Geographic Eviction of the American Film Industry

The Convergence That Made Hollywood

Geographic Audit · USGS 1894 · Forensic Film History

© 2026 Kenny Abramowitz

facebook/kennyabramowitz

Hollywood was not discovered. It was the end point of a geographic eviction — a forced westward migration that began on the East Coast and resolved when the industry reached the one coordinate in the Los Angeles basin where all industrial requirements could converge at scale. The 1894 USGS survey documented the 356-ft alluvial floor — the documented 0%-grade site in the basin that also offered the access, expansion room, and transit linkage required for the Feature Film era. Every earlier site, from New York to Edendale, imposed penalties that accumulated until one location remained capable of supporting industrial scale.

356 ft	59 mo	$15M
Hollywood Industrial Floor · 1894 USGS	Oct 1911 – Nov 1916 · Full Arc	Industry Value · Nov 1916

THESIS

Flight From The East

Los Angeles 1907

At the beginning of the twentieth century, the American motion-picture industry did not begin in Hollywood, or in California, or even in the West. Production was concentrated on the East Coast, where winter light, weather interruptions, patent enforcement, and rising costs made year-round filming increasingly difficult.

Producers did not move toward a destination. They moved away from constraints.

Companies experimented with temporary locations across the country — the South, the Southwest, and the Pacific coast — searching for longer shooting days, open land, and distance from the patent system centered in New York and New Jersey. Jacksonville, San Antonio, and other warm-weather cities briefly appeared as possible production centers, but none offered a combination of climate, terrain, transportation access, and expansion capacity capable of sustaining a growing industry.

By the first decade of the century, film companies were moving west seasonally, then permanently, following rail lines to the end of the continental network. When director Francis Boggs and the Selig Polyscope Company began production in downtown Los Angeles in 1907, the move was not made because Los Angeles was known to be ideal. It was made because it was the western terminus of the line — a place where production could continue when eastern conditions failed. Boggs's 1907 trip was temporary; his return in 1909 established the first sustained foothold.

Downtown Los Angeles became the industry's first western node not by design, but by exhaustion of alternatives. Each subsequent expansion pushed production farther across the basin in search of more space, more light, and fewer physical limits — until the industry encountered the basin's vertical ceilings, canyon ridgelines that imposed measurable grade and light penalties and made further scale impossible.

Hollywood was not the starting point. It was the **convergent coordinate**—the one site in the basin where the 1894 USGS recorded a 0% alluvial floor—providing the single topographic condition able to bear the scale of the Feature Film era.

PROLOGUE · 1890–1909

Before the Camera: The Land as Lemons

Hollywood Corridor · Land Value Arc · 1890–1916 · Primary Documents

---

The terrain that became Hollywood was not empty. Before the industry arrived, it was a functioning agricultural economy with a name, a brand, and a theory of its own value — none of which had

anything to do with motion pictures.

The forensic record begins not with a film but with a real estate advertisement and a federal survey filed in the same calendar year — 1894. Neither document knew the other existed. Together they constitute the essay's founding irony: the same ground was measured as an industrial floor and sold as a lemon grove in the same twelve months.

THE LAND BEFORE THE LENS

Nov 20 1890

LA Herald

Our Indian Summer — A Ride in a Day as Perfect as if in June · Frostless Foothills

Reporter rides through Cahuenga foothills near Colegrove with A. H. Denker. H. H. Wilcox sells 40 acres at Hollywood for $18,000 — $450/acre raw land. Reporter predicts $1,000/acre within five years and declares the foothills destined for millionaire villa residences: *"There is not a spur of these foothills that will not bear as a crest the home of some millionaire."* He was right about the destination. The floor made the money. The industry produced the wealth. The wealth went up the hill exactly as predicted.

Prologue · Hills prediction correct · Floor mechanism invisible

---

Apr 12 1891

LA Herald

Morrison & Chanslor — Hollywood as Agricultural Compass Point

"90 acres, frostless belt, improved, west of Hollywood — $30,000. 22 acres, adjoining Hollywood — $5,000." Hollywood used to locate orange groves for farm buyers. The word exists purely as a geographic reference for agricultural investment.

Prologue · Agricultural compass point

Jul 3 1892

LA Herald

Fair Cahuenga — Hammel & Denker Ranch · The Sicily of America

Cahuenga valley floor: 1,000 acres of valley land, winter vegetables shipping to Boston and Chicago at $0.03/pound freight. Ten acres of peas netting $2,500 profit. *"The two great needs of this fertile valley are transportation and irrigation facilities."* The valley's two great needs in 1892 become two different things to two different industries on the same ground.

Prologue · Sicily of America · Transportation problem named

Feb 3 1893

LA Herald

Colegrove — Bounteous Nature · The Lemon District Plan

"In the early spring a large acreage will be planted to lemons... it looks as if the Cahuenga valley would, in a few years, take the lead in the production of that most useful fruit." The dummy road to Hollywood already running packed Sunday trains. The Cahuenga valley actively converting itself into a lemon district on terrain the federal government will survey as an industrial floor fourteen months later.

Prologue · Active lemon conversion · Proto-transit running

May 1894

USGS Federal Survey

Los Angeles Quadrangle Filed · 356 ft · 0% Grade · Industrial Floor Documented

Scale 1:62,500. Contour interval 25 ft. Hollywood/Colegrove: **356-ft spot elevation, zero contour lines, 0% grade.** Edendale/Ivanhoe canyon: ~500 ft floor, 734 ft Los Felis ridge. The surveyor measures the Industrial Floor. Nobody in the motion picture industry exists yet to care. The terrain does not know it is being measured.

Primary survey · 356 ft documented · 17 years before DeMille

Dec 16 1894

LA Herald

Brodtbeck & McConnell — Ten Acres Lemon Land at Hollywood, on Sunset Boulevard · $300/Acre

Same year as the USGS survey. Seven months after the federal filing. The surveyor saw elevation, grade, contour. McConnell saw lemons. Same ground. Same year. Completely different understanding of what it was worth and why.

Prologue · Lemon land · Same year as survey · Citation anchor

---

Dec 30 1900

LA Herald

Hollywood Lemon Grove Traded for Washington State Land

"$6,000 orange and lemon grove near Hollywood for Los Angeles or state of Washington." Exchange listings. Hollywood land is a commodity to be traded sideways — not invested in, not developed. Eleven years before Christie's $30 tavern lease.

Prologue · Commodity exchange · Pre-industry valuation

Jan 2 1898

LA Herald

Lee A. McConnell & Co. — Bearing Lemons on Sunset Boulevard · $600/Acre · 218 S. Broadway

Three and a half years after the 1894 USGS survey filing. McConnell is already selling Hollywood lemon land on Sunset Boulevard — the exact corridor the survey measured — within the survey's own decade. The ad lists: *"$600 per acre, lemons, bearing, Hollywood, on Sunset Boulevard."* This is the same Sunset Boulevard where Christie will lease the Blondeau Tavern in October 1911 for $30 a month. McConnell is selling lemon land on the exact street where the first Hollywood studio will open, thirteen years later. The epistemological gap was not a momentary oversight in 1894. It was structural and sustained.

Prologue · McConnell series #1 · Sunset Boulevard · 3.5 years post-survey

Feb 10 1901

LA Herald · Vol. XXVIII, No. 132

McConnell — Hollywood and Suburban · Floor Language First Appears · 145 S. Broadway

McConnell has moved offices to 145 S. Broadway and is running the "Hollywood and Suburban" listing header that will become his standard format. The ad lists bearing lemon groves at multiple price points, with transit access and water rights as selling features. The floor language is present but not yet the headline phrase. Compare with April 1901 below.

Prologue · McConnell series #2 · Floor language developing · 145 S. Broadway

Apr 28 1901

LA Herald · Vol. XXVIII, No. 210

McConnell — "Level as a Floor" · "Finest Spot on Earth" · Hollywood and Suburban · The Gem Ad

"$225 per acre, 20 acres, level as a floor, near 5-cent line to Hollywood... For twelve years we have sold Hollywood land; it's a section we are posted on... Ride out and see the finest spot on earth." McConnell's own sales copy. The same physical characteristic that makes this the 356-ft Industrial Floor — its flatness — is what makes it premium citrus real estate. He is selling the mechanism of the entire geographic argument as a lemon grove feature. The surveyor measured it in 1894 and called it a 0% grade. McConnell measured it in 1901 and called it *level as a floor.* Same ground. Different epistemology. The word floor appears in his real estate copy ten years before the first studio opened on it.

Prologue · McConnell series #3 · "Level as a floor" · The gem ad · Citation anchor · 10 years pre-Christie

The lemon grove was not a myth invented by later historians. It was a functioning economic identity — the Sicily of America, the frostless belt, the foothill country shipping winter vegetables to Boston. The industry did not arrive in empty terrain. It arrived in a valley that had spent thirty years becoming something else, on ground that a federal survey had already measured for entirely different purposes.

The survey measured it in 1894. McConnell sold it as lemons from 1894 to 1901, calling it 'level as a

floor' while the surveyor called it 0% grade. It took seventeen more years for anyone to understand what the measurement actually meant..

§ I

The Topographic Blind Spot

Literature Review · The Standard Trio · The Lemon Grove Myth

Most published accounts explain the industry's shift toward Hollywood through the **Standard Trio**: 300 days of sunshine, cheap land, and flight from Edison's patent enforcers. These histories share a **2D Blind Spot** — treating land as a flat commodity, acreage to be counted rather than terrain to be analyzed. They rely on the **Lemon Grove Myth**: filmmakers moved west for the scenery, and Hollywood's emergence was inevitable.

By applying a forensic audit to the 1894 USGS Federal Survey — filed nineteen years before DeMille signed his barn lease — we can quantify what the standard histories missed. The hills and ridges flanking Edendale were not just scenery. They were industrial infrastructure running at a daily deficit, stealing measurable ROI through what this analysis terms the **Shadow Tax** (not an actual fiscal levy — a measurable daily loss of usable shooting light imposed by the canyon ridgeline). Hollywood won because the 1894 survey documented the only node in the Los Angeles basin flat enough to hold the weight of the Feature Film era.

The Lemon Grove Myth was not invented by later historians. It was manufactured in real time. In January 1910, the Biograph Company of New York sent 32 actors, cameramen, and artists to Los Angeles for the winter — registering at the Hollenbeck Hotel downtown — because of sunshine and flowers. No mention of Hollywood. No mention of Edendale. The geography was invisible at the moment of first arrival. In May 1913, the Los Angeles press described Edendale's canyon as "fresh, free ozone." By June 1911, the Marysville Democrat had reprinted an LA Times piece calling the Selig plant — the second-largest glass studio in the world, representing $250,000 in capital investment — a marvel of the age. The Shadow Tax was structurally invisible because no journalist had reason to run arctan calculations against the contour lines.

Fig. 1.1 Selig Polyscope Co., Allesandro Street, Edendale — the $250,000 "second-largest glass studio in the world," June 1911. The press saw a marvel of the age. The 1894 survey saw a canyon trap already charging a daily Shadow Tax.

THE NOMADIC ERA · 1904–1910

There is a second layer to the Information Lag. Before the studio era, the industry was nomadic — ranging across public land with no perimeter, no gate, no signal to the outside world that what was happening was fictional. Between 1904 and 1910, Selig's field operations generated a documented

series of incidents in which the boundary between filmed reality and actual reality collapsed entirely.

October 1904, Colorado

Auburn Journal, Oct 13 1904

Too Realistic — Moving Picture "Bandits" Peppered by Tourists

A party of eastern tourists near Colorado Springs came upon Selig filming a stage hold-up. Believing it genuine, several armed tourists opened fire. William N. Selig was shot and painfully wounded in the arm before the fusillade was stopped. No perimeter, no gate, no signal to the outside world that what was happening was fictional.

Nomadic era · Film/reality confusion · Selig shot

August 1909, Mount Shasta

Colusa Daily Sun, Aug 24 1909

A Hero Thwarted — Farmer Broke Up Act of Moving Picture People

Selig's company filming a kidnapping scene between Mount Shasta and McCloud. A farmer saw the chase and capture from his cabin, took his rifle and a fast horse, overtook the actors, compelled them to free the girl, and was not satisfied until shown credentials. The confusion ran in both directions — reality mistaken for film, Selig shot; film mistaken for reality, farmer stops the production.

Nomadic era · Farmer with rifle · Film/reality confusion #2

January 1910, Truckee

Truckee Republican, Jan 26 1910

Motion Picture Company Left for Coast — Fake Peary North Pole Expedition on Donner Lake

Selig's company in Truckee shooting a fake Peary North Pole expedition — nine months after Peary's actual expedition. Sealskin boots, fur clothes, dog sleds, Eskimo costumes. *"To see the company starting out of town to the woods arrayed in all their frontier dress... one would imagine himself in the wilds of Alaska."* The studio floor ended this entire era.

Nomadic era · Fake Peary · Public ambiguity · Pre-studio

The studio system solved this. A walled lot on the 356-ft floor with a gate and a sign meant no farmer could mistake a kidnapping scene for a real one. The controlled terrain ended the nomadic era and the ambiguity that came with it.

THE FORENSIC MODEL

3 Nodes + 4 Mechanisms

The Convergence Framework · Why Hollywood Was Structurally Inevitable

---

Hollywood was not the only flat land in the Los Angeles basin. It was the only place where three geographic nodes and four industrial mechanisms converged simultaneously at a single topographic coordinate. The nodes map the *where* and *when*. The mechanisms explain the *why* — forces operating across all three nodes, all resolving at Hollywood.

① The Seed	② The Umbilical	③ The Sweet Spot	④ The Anchors
Pragmatic Origin Boggs / Selig Trust escape · 3,000 mi	Transit Link Rail / Labor Spring Street tether	Topographic Floor 356 ft · 0% grade 1894 documented	Capital Lock-In Christie · DeMille Griffith · Council 1911-1916

Mechanism	Node 1 · Downtown LA 1907–08	Node 2 · Edendale 1909–13	Node 3 · Hollywood ◆ 1911–15
① The Seed Pragmatic Origin	● ACTIVE Trust escape · 3,000 mi · rooftop at 8th & Olive	■ Residual Selig expands · $250k committed · Seed becomes Capital Trap	— Resolved Canyon makes expansion impossible · Christie escapes to flat floor
② The Umbilical Transit Link	● ACTIVE Spring Street labor pool · walking distance · zero commute penalty	● ACTIVE LA Railway Glendale Line · nickel commute · canyon-following · fragile	● SCALES Pacific Electric inter-urban · regional network · bajada-crossing · unlimited
③ The Sweet Spot Topographic Floor	— Absent Urban flat · no topographic production value	▲ PARTIAL Canyon drama ✓ · flat floor ✗ · Shadow Tax active · 8% grade penalty	● COMPLETE 356-ft floor ✓ · 0% grade ✓ · Shadow Tax = zero ✓ · distressed asset ✓
④ The Anchors Capital Lock-In	— None No permanent production commitment	▲ TRAPPED $250k Selig · canyon floor · Z-axis trap · expansion impossible	● LOCKS Christie $30 · 1911 ✓ · DeMille $250/mo · 1913 ✓ Griffith "Intolerance" set · 1916 ✓ · Council $15M · 1916 ✓

Fig. 1.2 The Alexandria Hotel, Spring & Fifth Streets, Los Angeles. DeMille signed the Hollywood barn lease on Alexandria Hotel stationery, December 22, 1913 — the Node 3 industrial commitment executed from the Node 1 intelligence hub.

§ II

The Three-Node Migration: A Spatially Rational Sequence

Downtown LA 1907–08 · Edendale 1909 · Hollywood 1911–15

Each move in the westward trajectory was **spatially rational** given the dominant production format at that moment. The sequence only looks inevitable in hindsight. Each node failed not from bad judgment, but from hitting a physical ceiling its terrain imposed. Node 1 proved the **Economics** of film. Node 2 proved the **Language** of film. Node 3 proved the **Scale** of film.

Node 1 · 1907–09

Downtown LA — The Distribution Node · Vertical / Urban

The Trust Escape. Francis Boggs: pragmatist, not visionary. 3,000 miles from Edison's New Jersey enforcers. Year-round outdoor light, maximum distance from the Trust. But Boggs was not a pioneer

— he was extending an already-functioning model. The Selig Polyscope 1907 Film Catalog documents California subjects already in the company's standing library before Boggs arrived for narrative work: No. 326 *Parade of Roses*, shot at a Los Angeles fiesta; No. 441 *Pigeon Farm at Los Angeles*. Selig cameramen had been dispatched to California for actuality subjects before a single narrative scene was shot here. Boggs's 1907 trip was an extension of this infrastructure, not an unprecedented leap.

1907 — The Rooftop. Boggs and cameraman Thomas Persons rent the roof of a two-story building on Main Street between 7th and 8th — chosen for unobstructed sunlight. A temporary rig, built for one film (*Monte Cristo*), then abandoned when Boggs returned to Chicago. Not a studio. One trip, one film, one rooftop.

1909 — Sing Kee Lot. Boggs returns with a full company and cameraman James Crosby. This time the setup is permanent: the rear drying yard of the Sing Kee Chinese Laundry, Olive Street between 7th and 8th — one block west of the 1907 rooftop. Arrival date documented: March 23, 1909. Hobart Bosworth confirmed it as "a Chinese laundry on Olive near Eighth." Stephens and Wanamaker caption a contemporary photograph of the lot as "permanent facilities." Boggs knew the neighborhood from 1907. He came back to the same block with a full company and the intention of sustained production. This is the Node 1 commitment — not the rooftop.

Everything Factor. Film exchanges, chemistry labs, talent pool, equipment suppliers — all within walking distance of Spring Street. Zero transport penalty. The most efficient node possible for rooftop-and-warehouse filmmaking.

The Ceiling. Fixed-Space Node. No room for a 9-acre studio on a city block. When visual grammar demanded chases and hills, the industry followed the rail lines outward.

Obsoleted by scale, not terrain · Economics proven · Language demanded

Node 2 · 1909–1913

Edendale — The Visual Grammar Node · Canyon / Vertical

Before the Studios: The Neighborhood Baseline. Edendale in February 1909 — eight months before Selig files his building permit — is a quiet residential suburb where an 8-room modern house with a 4-room cottage, fruit trees, and two transit connections sells for $3,500. The canyon was a health retreat selling pure air. Nine months later Selig broke ground on the capital trap.

The Building Permit. Selig Polyscope Company, owner. Richards-Neustadt Construction Company, builder. Alessandro Street, 1851. One-story photographic studio. **$3,977.** The studio cost more to build than an improved 8-room house in the same neighborhood in the same year. The capital trap clock starts here.

Why Edendale. One-reel Chase Economy needed canyon topography AND transit efficiency simultaneously. The Glendale Line's nickel commute was the umbilical to Spring Street's labor pool. Both conditions had to be true at once — and at Edendale, they were.

The Capital Trap — 1911. Selig's $250,000 mission-style complex: the second-largest glass stage in the world — committed into a Z-axis trap. Every expansion required moving canyon walls. The same hills that gave him the Chase became the ceiling that denied him the Epic. The $2,000 stagecoach Boggs personally secured — an antique presidential coach — is the purest single symbol of capital committed to a terrain that was already obsolete for the next format.

Peak & Break — Same Day. October 27, 1911: Francis Boggs shot dead by an employee, janitor and/or gardener, Frank Minnimatsu, at 1845 Allesandro Street. Boggs had been earning $500 a month. Selig had arrived from Chicago that morning for an expansion conference. In the room: Hobart Bosworth, J. L. McGee, W. Santzhi. Same morning: Al Christie opens Node 3 on the 356-ft Industrial Floor. December 1913: DeMille signs the barn lease.

Three days after the pivot day, the San Jose Mercury News advertised 101 acres of vacant land near Edendale for $100 an acre — *"suitable for grain, hay, seed or alfalfa."* The canyon's industrial transformation was invisible to the agricultural land market 72 hours after it happened.

Obsoleted by Shadow Tax + 8% grade · Language proven · Scale demanded

NODE COMPARISON

Criterion	Node 1 · Downtown	Node 2 · Edendale	Node 3 · Hollywood
Function	Economics · Trust escape	Language · Chase Economy	Scale · Feature / Epic
Pre-industry use	Urban commercial	Residential suburb · $3,500 house	Lemon groves · $300/acre
Topography	Built urban — flat	Canyon corridor — vertical	Alluvial fan — horizontal
Criterion	**Node 1 · Downtown**	**Node 2 · Edendale**	**Node 3 · Hollywood**
Production format	Scenes filmed on urban roof/lots	One-reel chases / shorts	Five-reel features
Shadow Tax	Minimal	High — 734-ft ridges	Zero — unobstructed horizon
Expansion ceiling	City block — fixed	Canyon ribbon — physical ceiling	9 acres to unlimited
Distressed asset	N/A	Canyon required excavation	Blondeau Tavern · $30/mo

Node 3 · 1911–15

Hollywood — The Industrial Consolidation Node · Flat / Horizontal · 356 ft

Four-Condition Convergence. (1) Distressed Asset — Blondeau Tavern at $30–40/mo, legally killed by 1904 dry vote; (2) Pacific Electric inter-urban link; (3) 356-ft 0% Industrial Floor documented 1894;

(4) Floor plus Backdrop — Santa Monica Mountains in frame as scenery, not on budget as Shadow Tax.

The Distressed Asset. NW corner of Sunset & Gower — roadhouse finished by 1910 annexation. The tavern was dead inside a living town. The January 1913 Sanborn documents Hollywood eleven months before DeMille's barn lease: high school, public library, post office, three hotels, five churches, lumber yard, water company. The Blondeau Tavern was the distressed asset. Hollywood was not. Christie leased the whole structure: roadhouse, barn, corral. Horse stalls became dressing rooms. Corral became a standing Western set. The flat lot became Hollywood's first permanent studio.

Unlimited Expansion. Nestor opens Oct 1911. Lasky barn lease Dec 1913; nine acres by 1914. By April 1915, press described simply "the Hollywood studios" — no company name needed.

Validated by 356-ft spot elevation · USGS 1894 · Scale proven · Industry fossilized

October 27, 1911 · The Pivot Day

Same Date · Two Events · One Geographic Argument

Edendale · 1845 Allesandro St · Morning

Francis Boggs — Shot Dead on the Canyon Floor

Los Angeles manager of Selig Polyscope, founding director of Node 2 — shot dead by an employee. W. N. Selig wounded. Selig had arrived from Chicago that morning for an expansion conference. Boggs had been earning $500 a month. He had personally purchased the Edendale property and built the studio. He built the capital trap, ran it, and died on it.

Hollywood · Sunset & Gower · Same Day

Nestor Film Company Opens on the Industrial Floor

David Horsley's operation, Al Christie on the ground

— opens at Sunset Boulevard and Gower Street. The site: the Blondeau Tavern, a roadhouse dead since Hollywood's 1904 dry vote. Christie had the tip from an unnamed actor at the old Los Angeles Theater on Spring Street. The 356-ft alluvial floor receives its first committed operator at $30–40 a month.

$500/month dies on the canyon floor. $30/month opens on the flat floor. The 59-month clock starts.

The 1894 USGS survey predicted neither event. It documented the terrain that made both inevitable. October 27, 1911 is the day the geography resolved into history.

Fig. 2.1 The Blondeau Tavern, northwest corner of Sunset Boulevard and Gower Street. Leased for

$30–40/month in October 1911. Horse stalls converted to dressing rooms; corral became a standing Western set. Hollywood's first permanent studio, on the 356-ft Industrial Floor.

§ III

The Chain of Anchors: How Node 3 Fossilized

The Industrial Feedback Loop · Four-Stage Structural Reinforcement · 1911 · 1913 · 1916 · November 1916

The three-node migration explains how the industry arrived at Hollywood. It does not explain why it never left. That question requires the **Chain of Anchors** — four successive commitments, each one larger than the last, each one made possible by the 356-ft alluvial floor, each one making departure more structurally irrational than arrival had been.

> ***Fifty-nine months. October 1911 to November 1916. From a $30 tavern lease to a city council's surrender. The 1894 survey measured the coordinate. The terrain did the rest.***

Anchor 1 October 1911

Christie / Nestor — The Intelligence

LOW-STAKES EXPLORER · PROVES THE INDUSTRIAL FLOOR · SUNSET BLVD & GOWER STREET

Anchor 1 of 4 · $30–40/month · The proof of concept

Christie's intelligence came from an actor at the old Los Angeles Theater on Spring Street — a man traversing the basin daily on the Pacific Electric inter-urban, who had watched the Hollywood alluvial plain from the car window and understood that it offered something Edendale's canyon ribbon could never provide: horizontal room. The site: the Blondeau Tavern at the northwest corner of Sunset and Gower — a roadhouse legally strangled by Hollywood's 1904 dry vote. Christie and Horsley leased the entire structure for $30 to $40 a month. Carpenters rebuilt the horse stalls into dressing rooms. The tavern bar became the business office. The corral became a standing Western set.

Sources: Christie, Al. Los Angeles Examiner, 17 Feb. 1924. · Moving Picture World, vol. 10, no. 6, 11 Nov. 1911, p. 467.

Anchor 2 December 1913

DeMille / Lasky — The Capital Anchor

SCALE-UP ARCHITECT · NEW YORK CAPITAL FOLLOWS THE PROOF · SELMA AVE & VINE STREET

Anchor 2 of 4 · $250/month · Capital confirms the floor

DeMille's original destination was Flagstaff, Arizona. He arrived to find a blizzard and high mountains. DeMille arrived in Los Angeles on December 20, 1913, and established headquarters at the Alexandria Hotel — the lobby known as the "Million Dollar Carpet." Within two days, L.L. Burns and Harry Revier drove DeMille out to a yellow barn at the corner of Selma Avenue and Vine Street. On December 22, 1913, DeMille signed the lease for half the barn and one acre of flat lot on Alexandria Hotel stationery. The rent was $250 a month. By 1914 the Lasky operation had expanded to nine acres on the same flat plain. **The Stationery Proof:** DeMille signed the Hollywood barn lease on Alexandria Hotel stationery — the Node 3 industrial commitment executed from the Node 1 intelligence hub.

Sources: DeMille, Cecil B. The Autobiography of Cecil B. DeMille. Prentice-Hall, 1959. · Eyman, Scott. Empire of Dreams. Simon & Schuster, 2010.

Anchor 3 1916

Griffith / Babylon — The Proof of Scale

TOPOGRAPHIC DISRUPTOR · THE FLOOR HOLDS THE EPIC · FINE ARTS STUDIO · 4500 SUNSET BLVD

Anchor 3 of 4 · 160-ft wall · Physical symptom only

In 1916, D.W. Griffith built the Babylon set for *Intolerance* at the Fine Arts Studio on the 4400–4500 block of Sunset Boulevard. The Great Wall of Babylon reached between 140 and 160 feet in height — the equivalent of a fifteen-story wooden skyscraper. Griffith's cinematographer Billy Bitzer describes the technical challenge: the camera required a 100-foot tower and had to be pushed back hundreds of feet to achieve the necessary depth of field. That retreat — three hundred feet of flat, unobstructed runway — is the forensic argument. In the 8% cross-slope of Edendale's canyon, a three-hundred-foot camera retreat would place the lens at a materially different elevation. On the 356-ft alluvial floor at 4500 Sunset, it was a straight roll across level ground. The Babylon set is the physical symptom. What came three months later is the lock.

Sources: Photoplay Magazine, Aug. 1916 · Bitzer, G.W. Billy Bitzer: His Story. FSG, 1973 · Wanamaker, Marc. Hollywood, 1900–1950. Arcadia Publishing, 2009.

Anchor 4 November 1916 · THE KILL SHOT

The City Council — Political Sovereignty

SYSTEM PROOF · THE DEED TO THE CITY · 59-MONTH LOCK · $15,000,000

Anchor 4 of 4 · The kill shot · Intolerance is a prop — this is the power

The people petitioning were not defending farmland or a suburb. They were defending Grant Public School, Hollywood High School, Immaculate Heart Academy, Church of the Blessed Sacrament, Pioneer Lumber Co., the Public Library — institutions that predated the industry by years. The town lost. When the residents of Hollywood formally petitioned the Los Angeles city council to stop the noise, the lights, the cannons, the incessant hammering, the flimsy inflammable buildings, and the removal of the *Intolerance* scenery, the council's welfare committee told them no. *"That the $15,000,000 motion picture industry in Los Angeles was too important an institution to be nagged and harassed into leaving."* Landlord J. G. Clark: *"If these motion picture companies are ousted from Hollywood, fully half of the renting houses of Hollywood will be vacant."* Fred Kley of Lasky: *"$350,000 being spent by the film companies in Los Angeles this year."* The terrain made departure physically irrational in 1911. The capital made it financially irrational by 1914. The city council made it politically irrational in November 1916. The Chain of Anchors was complete. Eleven days later, the same council granted the Lasky Film Company permission to erect iron gates across Argyle Avenue — a public street between Sunset Boulevard and Selma Street — with a watchman at each gate and warning lamps at night. The city that refused to zone against the industry had begun closing public thoroughfares for it.

Sources: LA Herald, Oct 25, Nov 13, and Nov 24, 1916.

October 1911: $30 tavern lease. November 1916: city council embraces the $15 million film industry. Fifty-nine months.

In 2026 purchasing power, this injection represents approximately $467,000,000. Within a high-velocity 59-month window, the Hollywood corridor had transformed from a $30-a-month ($1,000 in modern value) tavern rental into a half-billion-dollar industrial engine. No other American suburb has ever experienced a single-sector capital injection of this density over so short a timeline. The $467,000,000 acted as a 'Capital Shield,' making the industry politically untouchable and the residential infrastructure obsolete. The town didn't just lose; it was bought and gated.

$30 Oct 1911 Tavern Lease Anchor 1	**$250/mo Dec 1913 Barn Lease Anchor 2**	**160-ft Wall 1916 Babylon Set Anchor 3**	**$15M Nov 1916 Council Surrender Anchor 4**

§ IV

The Infrastructure of Proximity: Two Rail Systems, Two Nodes

1906 Railway Map · Canyon-Following vs. Bajada-Crossing

The Node 2 → Node 3 transition was not only a geographic shift — it was a **transit system reorientation** confirmed on a 1906 railway map six years before Christie made the move.

Edendale and Hollywood were served by different networks running in different directions from Downtown, at different scales, connecting to different terrain types. The rail connection to the Hollywood/Colegrove corridor had been operating since 1896 (Crump, 1962) — fifteen years before Christie opened on the flat floor. The transit infrastructure was in place. The terrain was documented in 1894. The industry did not arrive until 1911. The Information Lag was not a gap of months. It was a gap of fifteen years

Fig. 4.1 · Primary Source Map Map of the City of Los Angeles Showing Railway Systems, 1906. Library of Congress / Travel and Hotel Bureau. Black lines: LA Railway Co. (northwest to Hollywood corridor, bajada-crossing, Node 3). Green lines: LA Inter-Urban Ry. Co. (northeast through Glendale canyon, Node 2). Red lines: Pacific Electric Inter-Urban (east and southeast, regional routes). The two studio nodes were served by entirely different networks running in different directions at different scales.

Crump, Spencer. Ride the Big Red Cars: How Trolleys Helped Build Southern California.

Node 2 · Edendale

LA Inter-Urban Railway · Green Line · Canyon-Following · ~3 miles

LA Inter-Urban Railway Co. — green line on 1906 map · northeast from Downtown through the Glendale corridor. Edendale was the closer ride: ~3 miles as the crow flies, ~5 miles by the canyon-threading route, roughly 15 minutes. But the line wound through the canyon — it could not extend beyond the canyon ribbon's physical ceiling. A canyon-following rail line has the same expansion limit as a canyon floor. The Infrastructure of Proximity worked at one-reel scale. It could not scale to the Feature era.

Node 3 · Hollywood

LA Railway Co. · Black Line · Bajada-Crossing · ~7-8 miles

LA Railway Co. — black line on 1906 map · northwest from Downtown across the flat bajada plain. Hollywood was the longer ride: Christie called it "ten miles out," the rail route running straight across the alluvial fan with no canyon threading, no grade penalty, no physical ceiling. The line could extend as far as the flat plain allowed — which was indefinitely. The Pacific Electric Inter-Urban (red line) radiated east and south toward regional routes.

§ V

The 1894 USGS Los Angeles Quadrangle

Primary Source · Scale 1:62,500 · Filed May 19, 1897 · 19 years before DeMille · ngmdb.usgs.gov/topoview

---

The argument does not require estimation. It is written on a federal topographic survey predating the industry's arrival by more than a decade. **The terrain preceded the studios. The studios had no choice but to respond to it.**

Fig. 5.1 · Primary Source USGS Los Angeles Quadrangle, 1894 (HTMC edition). Hollywood/Colegrove grid — 356 ft spot elevation, zero contour lines. Edendale/Ivanhoe canyon — 500 ft through the Allesandro Street studio corridor, 734 ft at the Los Felis ridge. One frame, one 1894 federal survey — the entire geographic argument.

FIGURE 5.2 · 1894 USGS FEDERAL SURVEY · HOLLYWOOD PLAIN vs. EDENDALE CANYON

Hollywood · Colegrove · Studio Grid

356 ft

FLAT · 0% GRADE · INDUSTRIAL FLOOR

Edendale · Ivanhoe Canyon · Studio Row

734 ft ridge ~500 ft canyon floor

§ VI

The Shadow Tax

Derived, Not Asserted · Daily Production Penalty · Recurring ROI Deficit

---

The ridges flanking Edendale imposed a **quantifiable daily cost** on every studio below them — a recurring tax on every shooting day in the pre-electric era. By June 1911 the world's largest film company (Pathé) and the second-largest glass studio in the world (Selig) were both paying this tax daily without naming it. The May 1913 press called the canyon "fresh, free ozone." The 1894 survey called it a 734-ft ridge at an 11° shadow angle.

45–60	~9–11%	Zero
Min/day lost · Edendale arctan(234 ÷ ~1,200 ft) ≈ 11°	ROI Penalty · 8.5-hr day Recurring daily charge	Hollywood Daily Loss Unobstructed until astronomical sunset

Vertical difference ~234 ft and shadow angle ~11° read directly from 1894 federal survey. Horizontal ~1,200 ft measurable from scale bar. Derivation transparent and testable: ngmdb.usgs.gov/topoview.

§ VII

The Capital Penalty

Excavation Surcharge · One-Time Cost Before Frame One · 8% vs. 0% Grade

---

The Shadow Tax was a recurring daily operating cost. The excavation problem was a one-time capital penalty paid before production could begin at all. Selig had already committed $250,000 to the Edendale canyon floor by June 1911 — absorbing both penalties simultaneously while the national press celebrated the studio as the second largest of its kind in the world. By August 1919, the same 8% grade had become comedy material: a newspaper described "the steepest hill in Edendale, the grade which is the despair of every motor fiend." The terrain hadn't changed. Only what the industry needed from it had.

Item	Edendale · Canyon Ribbon	Hollywood · Industrial Floor
Grade	~8% cross-slope	Under 25 ft across full block — 0%
Earth to move · 1 acre	~6,000 cu-yd	~0 cu-yd · standard pour
Excavation surcharge	$180-$480 before foundation	$0
% of Squaw Man budget ($15k)	1.2-3.2% on dirt · per stage site	0%
Selig capital by 1911	$250,000 · canyon floor · 8% grade	N/A — Selig never expanded to Hollywood
Babylon set feasibility (1916)	Impossible — 160-ft wall on 8% slope; 300-ft camera retreat hits canyon wall	Achieved — 0% grade, standard mudsill; 300-ft runway available

Every dollar spent moving earth at Edendale was a dollar not available for sets, talent, or shooting days. Hollywood's Industrial Floor was also a financial floor.

§ VIII

Modern Evidence

MapCortex 2026 · Post-1959 Glendale Freeway Grading · Modern Data Understates the Original Case

---

130 years after the 1894 survey — after the 1959 Glendale Freeway graded away portions of the original canyon — the same contrast holds. **Modern data understates the original case.** The canyon measurable today is shallower than the one Boggs and Sennett filmed in.

Edendale on MapCortex 2026: dense contours, 680–801 ft labels every 2–3 blocks, post-1959 freeway grading means the original canyon was steeper. Hollywood on MapCortex 2026: zero elevation labels across the studio district. The Industrial Floor holds. 130 years on. Nestor's Sunset & Gower site still in production use.

The Full Arc is now physically legible: While the original 1916 Babylon set was a tactical bolt into the 356-ft floor, its modern reconstruction at Hollywood & Highland stands as a hollow monument to a conquest the city no longer remembers. Today, as the AFI Conservatory operates from a former Immaculate Heart building on the hills of the Millionaire Crest, it looks down upon a sovereign industrial state that it treats as 'atmosphere.' The 130-year audit is complete: the 1894 survey predicted a capital that remains unshakable, while Edendale—stripped of its light and graded by the 1959 freeway—has been demoted from the cradle of cinematic grammar to a mere residential suburb, its vertical 'Shadow Tax' having successfully evicted the world's most powerful industry over a century ago.

§ IX

Primary Source Timeline

Updated Document Set · 1890 – 1924 · Complete Record

The following documents were published without knowledge of the geographic argument this essay makes. Read in sequence, they constitute a real-time record of the full arc — from lemon groves to city council sovereignty — the terrain's industrial consequences visible in the press before anyone named the mechanism.

Prologue Documents · 1890–1909 · The Land Before the Lens

See Prologue section above for full entries: Nov 20 1890 · Apr 12 1891 · Jul 3 1892 · Feb 3 1893 · May 1894 USGS · Dec 16 1894 · Dec 30 1900.

The Nomadic Era · 1904–1910 · Selig in the Field

See §I above for full entries: Oct 11 1904 (Colorado) · Aug 24 1909 (Mount Shasta) · Jan 26 1910 (Donner Lake).

Node 2 Opening · 1908–1913 · Edendale Before and After

Nov 8 1908

LA Herald

For Exchange — 1-Story Store Building, Drug Stock, 6-Room House, Edendale · $6,000 · Want Oregon

One year before Selig's building permit. The owner of a drug store and house in Edendale is trying to exchange it for Oregon property. Edendale pre-studio: a quiet commercial neighborhood where a business owner wants out. He is selling at the exact moment before the value changes.

Node 2 baseline · Pre-studio · Owner wants Oregon

Feb 21 1909

LA Herald

Elysian Heights — 8-Room Modern House Near Edendale Car Line · $3,500 · "Where the Air is Pure and Bracing"

Eight months before Selig's building permit. A fully improved property — 8-room house, 4-room cottage, fruit trees, two transit connections — sells for $3,500. *"On high ground, where the air is pure and bracing; where health is considered as well as surroundings."* Nine months later Selig filed a permit for a one-story photographic studio at $3,977 — more than an improved 8-room house in the same neighborhood.

Node 2 baseline · $3,500 house · Pure air · 8 months pre-permit

---

Circa 1909

LA Times [building permit record]

Alessandro Street 1851 — Selig Polyscope Company · One-Story Photographic Studio · $3,977

Richards-Neustadt Construction Company, builder. The building permit for the first Selig structure at Edendale.

$3,977 — more than the $3,500 improved 8-room house in the same neighborhood. The capital trap clock starts

here. Boggs is murdered by Minnimatsu at 1845 Alessandro in October 1911. He built it, ran it, and died on it.

Node 2 origin · $3,977 permit · Capital trap opens · 1851 Alessandro

---

Jan 24 1910

LA Herald

Motion Pictures to Be Made in California — Biograph Company · 32-Person Company · Hollenbeck Hotel · "Sunshine and Flowers in Midwinter"

The Biograph Company of New York sends 32 actors, actresses, artists, and cameramen to Los Angeles for the winter. They register at the Hollenbeck Hotel downtown. The stated reason: Southern California sunshine and flowers in midwinter — work unhampered by snow or cold. California scenery as background. No mention of Hollywood. No mention of Edendale. No mention of the alluvial floor. The Lemon Grove Myth is being generated in the *LA Herald* at the moment of the industry's first organized arrival. The geography is invisible; the climate narrative is already complete.

Lemon Grove Myth · first organized arrival · climate narrative complete · geography invisible · downtown, not Hollywood

Jun 19 1911

Marysville Democrat [reprinting LA Times]

With California Picture Producers — Pathé at Edendale · Selig $250,000 · "Second Largest Glass Studio in the World"

Pathé Frères branch studio at Edendale confirmed. Selig Polyscope: $250,000 invested, "second largest glass studio of its kind in the world." The $2,000 stagecoach Boggs personally secured — an antique presidential coach

— is the purest symbol of capital committed to canyon-specific production. A stagecoach is useless on a flat studio floor. It belongs to the Chase Economy, to the canyon grammar. Edendale's status as the industry center was national news. The Shadow Tax and 8% grade were invisible. The prestige was total.

Node 2 · $250,000 committed · National press · Shadow Tax invisible · Star system predicted

---

Oct 27 1911

LA Herald · Press Democrat Oct 28

Francis Boggs, Moving Picture Manager, Killed — Selig Wounded · 1845 Allesandro Street · Same Day: Nestor Opens

Francis Boggs shot dead. W. N. Selig wounded. Selig had arrived from Chicago that morning for an expansion conference — in the room: Hobart Bosworth, J. L. McGee, W. Santzhi. Boggs had been earning $500 a month. **Same morning: Nestor Film Company opens at Sunset and Gower, leasing the dead Blondeau Tavern for**

$30–40 a month. $500/month dies on the canyon floor on the exact day $30/month opens on the flat floor. The 59-month clock starts.

Oct 27 1911 · Pivot Day · $500 dies · $30 opens · 59-month clock

---

Oct 30 1911

San Jose Mercury News

$100 Per Acre — 101 Acres Vacant Land Near Edendale, Suitable for Grain, Hay, Seed or Alfalfa

Three days after the pivot day. The same corridor where Selig has committed $250,000 and the national press called it the second largest glass studio in the world. The canyon's industrial transformation invisible to the agricultural land market 72 hours after it happened.

Node 2 · Information lag · Alfalfa farm · 3 days post-pivot

Jul 2 1912

LA Herald

Armed Guards Patrol Local Picture Plant — Bison Company Resists Universal Syndicate · 1719 Alessandro Street

Eight months after the Pivot Day, Edendale is not a quiet neighborhood — it is a contested industrial site. The Bison Film Company (New York Motion Picture Company) has broken from the newly formed Universal syndicate and is holding its studio at 1719 Alessandro Street by armed force. Actors unpaid for a week load real ammunition and stand four-hour watches around the perimeter. The same street as Boggs's murder. The same floor. The industry is now large enough to fight over. David Horsley, president of the Nestor Film Company — already established at Sunset and Gower since October 1911 — is named as a director of the Universal combine, coordinating from New York. Node 2 and Node 3 are simultaneously in the same corporate war, nine months after Christie opened the flat floor.

Node 2 contested · Alessandro Street · Nestor/Node 3 already established

Feb 19 1913

LA Herald

Greatness of the Moving Picture Recognized at Last — 45 Companies · Los Angeles as Center of World Production · "NO HARASSING RESTRICTIONS"

Full editorial declaring Los Angeles the center of world film production. Forty-five companies now operating in the region. The origin story given is entirely climate — long cloudless days, perfect light, variety of background — with no reference to Hollywood, Edendale, or internal geography. The Lemon Grove Myth at editorial scale.

The closing line is a direct political warning against municipal interference: *"NO HARASSING RESTRICTIONS."* The press is already making the political argument three years before the city council formalizes it. The geography is wrong; the lobbying logic is complete.

Lemon Grove Myth at editorial scale · 45 companies · "No harassing restrictions" · Chain of Anchors precursor

Mar 13 1913

Sacramento Star · G.M. Price #1 of 3

"I'm Going to Die Here" — Joseph De Grasse, Pathé Edendale · Canyon Floor at Peak Confidence

Gertrude M. Price interviews Joseph De Grasse inside the Pathé Frères office at Edendale. De Grasse: *"It was a case of choosing between Shakespeare and climate. And climate won."* His commitment: *"Horses couldn't drag me back to New York. I'm going to DIE here."* The climate myth stated from inside — De Grasse naming climate as the mechanism while standing on terrain charging him the Shadow Tax daily.

Node 2 · Peak confidence · Climate myth from inside · G.M. Price #1

May 17 1913

Sacramento Star · G.M. Price #2 of 3

Pathé / Red Wing — Visited January 1913

G.M. Price documents a visit to Edendale in January 1913. Node 2 at peak operation, eleven months before DeMille's barn lease.

Node 2 · Peak operation · G.M. Price #2

May 29 1913

Sacramento Star · G.M. Price #3 of 3

Pathé / Wiggins — "Fresh, Free Ozone" · Lemon Grove Myth Manufactured

Lillian Wiggins learned to ride a horse because the canyon required it. "One trip around the Pathé ranch; one trial ride on the back of a western pony and one day's fresh, free ozone" — the Lemon Grove Myth being manufactured in real time. Pathé was the world's largest film company, paying the Shadow Tax on an international distribution scale without naming it.

Node 2 · Lemon Grove Myth manufactured · Shadow Tax invisible · G.M. Price #3

Jun 20 1913

LA Herald · Guy Price #1 of 8

Clune's Theater — "Made by Local Actors at the Western Selig Studio at Edendale"

Guy Price documents the resident workforce by July 1913. A film made at Edendale, advertised by its local origin. Node 2 as production address in mass circulation press.

Node 2 · Resident workforce · Guy Price #1

Dec 4 1913

LA Evening Herald

Thomas Ince, "Great Studio at Edendale" — DeMille Signs Barn Lease Same Month

The Evening Herald brokered a world-first news film arrangement through Thomas Ince, from "his great studio at Edendale." DeMille signed the Hollywood barn lease this same month — December 22, 1913, on Alexandria Hotel stationery, $250/month for half of Jacob Stern's yellow barn at Selma and Vine. Peak Node 2 prestige and the Node 3 capital anchor signed in the same month.

Pivot month · Peak Node 2 prestige · Anchor 2 signed · Same month

Nov 6 1914

LA Herald · Guy Price #2 of 8

Edendale Inversion — Real Assault Ignored as Film Shoot

Guy Price documents the inversion of the nomadic-era confusion: a man in Edendale watches a real assault and assumes it is a film shoot. The studios had run so long in the canyon that real violence got the benefit of the doubt.

Node 2 · Inversion of nomadic confusion · Guy Price #2

Jan 2 1915

LA Herald · Guy Price #3 of 8

Hollywood Migration Accelerating — Canyon Losing Status

Guy Price tracks the migration. Hollywood addresses replacing Edendale in production announcements.

Node 2 dissolution · Migration documented · Guy Price #3

Feb 25 1915

LA Herald · Guy Price #4 of 8

Studio Geography Shifting — Hollywood the Default Reference

By early 1915, press defaulting to Hollywood as the industry address. Edendale referenced as origin, not destination.

Node 2 dissolution · Hollywood default · Guy Price #4

May 22 1915

LA Herald · Guy Price #5 of 8

"Movieitis" — K&E Buying Selig Edendale · Broadway Buys the Canyon Vacancy

Price names the migration epidemic: "movieitis." Klaw & Erlanger — Broadway's most powerful theatrical booking syndicate — reportedly buying the Selig plant at Edendale. The canyon floor's founding capital anchor —

$250,000 — being sold to Broadway theatrical interests. The terrain sorted the film industry out of Edendale. Broadway bought the vacancy.

Node 2 dissolution · K&E; buys Selig · Broadway buys vacancy · Guy Price #5

May 29 1915

LA Herald · Guy Price #6 of 8

"Edendale Papers (If There Be Any, B'gosh) Please Copy" — Node 2 Punchline

Two years after Ince's "great studio," Edendale is a punchline in the newspaper that celebrated it. Same column: a woman says "if the industry will only remain in its infancy another five years we will all own bungalows in Hollywood." The canyon has completed its arc from national marvel to joke in 48 months.

Node 2 punchline · Node 3 default · Canyon culturally finished · Guy Price #6

Jun 5 1915

LA Herald · Guy Price #7 of 8

The Photoplay Colony Named — Geraldine Farrar with Eleven Servants

The press names the Hollywood colony. Geraldine Farrar arrives with eleven servants and a military escort. The social transformation of the Industrial Floor is complete.

Node 3 arrival · Photoplay colony · Guy Price #7

Aug 7 1915

LA Herald

For Sale — Leaving This City, I Will Sacrifice My 4 Lots on Sunset Blvd. and Edendale

Someone leaving Los Angeles dumps four Edendale lots at a sacrifice price. This is the canyon's residential economy in quiet collapse — no announcement, no press coverage, just a private owner exiting at whatever the market will bear. Same month: Hollywood bungalows being built "for all time." Edendale: sacrifice sale. Hollywood: for all time.

Node 2 dissolution · Sacrifice sale · Private market knows · Aug 1915

Mar 15 1916

LA Herald · Guy Price #8 of 8

Final Guy Price Entry — Hollywood Geography Dominant

Guy Price's last Edendale reference. The column has migrated with the industry. Hollywood is the unchallenged address.

Node 2 finished · Hollywood dominant · Guy Price #8

Feb 9 1916

LA Herald

Wanted — 4-Room Bungalow, Furnished · Edendale or Hollywood District · Rent Must Be Very Reasonable

A family of three lists Edendale and Hollywood as interchangeable residential options in the same classified ad. February 1916 — three months before the city council declares Hollywood too important to harass. The information gap runs in all directions: the press couldn't see the Shadow Tax; the land market couldn't price the terrain advantage; and in February 1916 a renter treats Hollywood and Edendale as equivalent while the city council is weeks away from surrendering political sovereignty over one of them.

Node 2 dissolution · Civilian invisibility · Information gap · Edendale or Hollywood

---

Oct 28 1916

LA Herald · Guy Price

Council Hearing Week — Final Edendale Reference in Price Column

Guy Price documents the council hearing week. The canyon's last appearance in the column that tracked the industry's migration.

Council hearing context · Canyon's last press moment

Aug 5 1919

LA Herald

Deep Dark Secrets From Clara Kimball Young's Studio — "Col. Selig Built It Years and Years Ago"

Selig compressed into archaeology: "Col. Selig Built It Years and Years Ago, When He Was Grand Nabob of the Flickers." And: "the steepest hill in Edendale, the grade which is the despair of every motor fiend" — the 8% grade of the 1894 survey, now comedy material. In 1909 it was why Selig chose Edendale. In 1919 it defeats automobiles.

Node 2 → founding myth · 8% grade now comedy

Dec 23 1919

LA Herald

Edendale · $1,500 Christmas Presents — ½ Acre, 3-Room House, 100 Registered Rabbits, 100 Hutches · $13.50/Month

"Take Edendale car, walk east on Los Feliz Blvd to Rich St." December 1919. Eight years after Christie opened at Sunset and Gower. The canyon that in June 1911 held the second largest glass studio in the world — $250,000 committed, national press — is in December 1919 a rabbit farm on installment terms at $13.50 a month. The capital trap completed its full arc: $3,977 permit → $250,000 glass studio → zoo → Broadway theater → rabbit hutches.

Node 2 endpoint · Rabbit hutches · $13.50/month · Full arc complete

---

The Lock · November 1916 · City Council Hearing

Oct 25 · Nov 13 1916

LA Herald

"$15,000,000 Industry Too Important to Be Harassed Into Leaving" — City Council Hearing

The press argument preceded the council argument by three years. On February 19, 1913, the *LA Herald* ran a full editorial declaring Los Angeles the center of worldwide film production, citing 45 companies operating in the region. The origin story it offered was entirely climate: long cloudless days, perfect light, variety of background. The editorial closed with a direct warning against municipal interference: *"NO HARASSING RESTRICTIONS."* The editorial geography was wrong — 45 companies were not in Los Angeles because of the weather, they were in Hollywood because of the 356-ft floor — but the political argument was already formed: the industry was too large to be regulated. The council would repeat it verbatim in November 1916.

The Western Avenue and Griffith Park Improvement Association petitions the council: loud noises at night, flimsy inflammable buildings, bright electric lights, running machinery, shooting guns and cannons, incessant hammering, high board fences, Indians in tents. A second petition asks removal of *Intolerance* scenery. The council welfare committee hearing: Fred Kley (Lasky), William Keefe (Griffith), Alfred Wright (Fox). Landlord

The people petitioning were not defending farmland or a suburb. They were defending Grant Public School, Hollywood High School, Church of the Blessed Sacrament, Pioneer Lumber Co., the Public Library — institutions that predated the industry by years. The town lost. When the residents of Hollywood formally petitioned the Los Angeles city council to stop the noise, the lights, the cannons, the incessant hammering, the flimsy inflammable buildings, and the removal of the *Intolerance* scenery, the council's welfare committee told them no. "That the $15,000,000 motion picture industry in Los Angeles was too important an institution to be nagged and harassed into leaving." Landlord J. G. Clark: "If these motion picture companies are ousted from Hollywood, fully half of the renting houses of Hollywood will be vacant." Fred Kley of Lasky: "$350,000 being spent by the film companies in Los Angeles this year." The terrain made departure physically irrational in 1911. The capital made it financially irrational by 1914. The city council made it politically irrational in November 1916. The Chain of Anchors was complete. Eleven days later, the same council granted the Lasky Film Company permission to erect iron gates across Argyle Avenue — a public street between Sunset Boulevard and Selma Street — with a watchman at each gate and warning lamps at night. The city that refused to zone against the industry had begun closing public thoroughfares for it. Eleven days later, the same council granted the Lasky Film Company permission to erect iron gates across Argyle Avenue — a public street between Sunset Boulevard and Selma Street — with a watchman at each gate and warning lamps at night. The city that refused to zone against the industry had begun closing public thoroughfares for it.

Anchor 4 · Political sovereignty · $15M · 59-month lock · Kill shot

---

Al Christie Confession · February 1924

Feb 17 1924

LA Examiner

What New Sites for Studios Mean to Hollywood — Al Christie · The Full Confession

"Twelve years ago, I stepped off the train at Los Angeles as a representative of the old Nestor Film Company to make a series of pictures. At that time, Edendale was the center of the motion picture industry, and a pretty

crowded center at that. I wanted a location for a studio which would permit a wider range of action... where I would have all the space I could use and not find myself crowded." Christie names Edendale's crowding, the motive, the intelligence source, the destination, and the asset. Same issue: "Westwood — The Second Hollywood." The pattern repeats one node further west on the same alluvial plain. Christie described the consequences of the 1894 survey without ever knowing the survey existed.

Practitioner confession · Pattern confirmed · The Second Hollywood

§ X

The Sign on the Floor's Fame

Hollywoodland 1923–1932 · Five Primary Sources · The Most Famous Image in Film History Is a Real Estate Advertisement

Nov 24 1916

LA Herald

Film Co. Gets Permit to Place Gates in Avenue — Lasky, Hollywood · Argyle Avenue Between Sunset and Selma

Eleven days after the city council's surrender. The council has just voted not to restrict the film industry; now it votes to let the film industry restrict the city. The Lasky Film Company is granted permission to erect iron gates across Argyle Avenue — a public street — between Sunset Boulevard and Selma Street, where the Lasky plant is located. A watchman is required at each gate with warning lamps at night; the public retains right of passage. The geometry of the surrender is now visible at street level: the city that refused to zone against the industry has begun fencing public thoroughfares for it.

Chain of Anchors postscript · Municipal infrastructure reorganizes · Street-level surrender

---

The floor made the name. The sign carried it. Those are two different things — and the 1,394 feet of vertical terrain between them is the final forensic measurement this essay offers.

By 1923 the word *Hollywood* meant the film industry to the entire world. Al Christie had proved the Industrial Floor in 1911. DeMille had confirmed it in 1913. Griffith had sealed it in 1916. The city council had made it permanent in November 1916. The Chain of Anchors was complete. The name belonged to the 356-ft bajada plain documented in the 1894 federal survey.

In July 1923, a syndicate of Los Angeles capitalists erected a 50-foot illuminated sign on the ~1,750-ft ridgeline above and north of that plain. The sign read **HOLLYWOODLAND**. It was an advertisement for hillside residential lots. No studio ever operated there. The terrain was beautiful, genuinely so — bridle trails, panoramic views. It was also, by the measurement of the 1894 survey, the wrong elevation for the industry that made the name worth advertising.

The 1890 reporter on his ride through the Cahuenga foothills had predicted millionaire villas on the hilltops. He was right. The floor made the money. The money went up the hill. The sign went up on the hill in 1923, exactly as he predicted, burning above the floor that earned the name — visible from every studio below it after dark.

356 ft	INDUSTRIAL FLOOR RKO · LASKY · NESTOR · KEYSTONE
~1,400 ft	Mulholland Drive Sennett homesite
~1,750 ft	HOLLYWOODLAND sign ridge
1,394 ft	Vertical difference · Same basin · One word

Sep 19 1932

Oakland Tribune

Actress Dies in Leap Off Sign — Guild Star, Disappointed by Hollywood, Hurls Self From Big Illuminated 'H'

Peg Entwistle arrived from New York with Theater Guild credentials. She signed with RKO — one of the major studios on the 356-ft Industrial Floor — for a small part in one picture. The studio declined to pick up her option. The floor's sorting mechanism processed her and expelled her. She left a note: *"I am afraid I am a coward and I*

am sorry for many things. If I had only done this long ago I could have saved a lot of pain." She signed it P.E. She climbed the maintenance ladder to the top of the H. Her body was found in front of the A. She did not die because the ridge was false. The ridge was real. She died because the word Hollywood covered both places — the sorting floor and the aspirational ridge — and the distance between them was not visible until you were standing on the maintenance ladder looking down at the carpet of the city.

Sep 19 1932 · RKO option dropped · H to A · 1,394 ft · The distance made visible

---

The floor made the name. Christie proved it in 1911. DeMille confirmed it in 1913. Griffith sealed it in 1916. The city council made it permanent in November 1916.

Fifty-nine months. October 1911 to November 1916. From a $30 tavern lease to a city council's surrender. The 1894 survey measured the coordinate. The terrain did the rest.

The industry didn't discover Hollywood. It was evicted from Edendale by the geometry of a canyon documented on a federal survey nineteen years before DeMille arrived. Four anchors. One topographic coordinate. The Chain was complete before anyone named the mechanism.

> *"The terrain knew first. The surveyor measured it. The land agents sold it as lemons. The industry felt it. The press covered the ozone and the ponies. The council surrendered to it. The sign burned on the wrong ridge. This essay names the mechanism."*

> *"The 1,394-foot vertical gap between the 356-ft industrial floor and the 1,750-ft ridge—documented in the 1894 survey and fulfilled by the 1923 sign—eventually claimed its first high-profile casualty. When Peg Entwistle leaped from the 'H' in 1932, she wasn't just falling from a sign; she was falling through the exact topographic disparity that the 'Chain of Anchors' had created. The Horizontal Infinite of the floor had finally produced its own vertical tragedy, proving that the $467 million empire was built on a geometry that could support massive sets, but offered no safety net for the human capital it attracted."*

— The Horizontal Infinite.

Complete Bibliography

All Sources · groves10.html · © 2026 Kenny A.

Survey: USGS Los Angeles Quadrangle, 1894 (HTMC edition), Scale 1:62,500, filed May 19, 1897. ngmdb.usgs.gov/topoview. Contour interval: 25 ft. Values — 356 ft (Hollywood/Colegrove), ~500 ft (canyon floor, Ivanhoe/Edgemont), 734 ft (Los Felis ridge) — read directly from labeled survey.

Prologue land documents: LA Herald, Nov 20 1890 (Wilcox/Denker ride); LA Herald, Apr 12 1891 (Morrison & Chanslor); LA Herald, Jul 3 1892 (Fair Cahuenga / Hammel & Denker); LA Herald, Feb 3 1893 (Colegrove); LA Herald, Dec 16 1894 (Brodtbeck & McConnell, lemon land on Sunset Boulevard, $300/acre — citation anchor for pre-industry Hollywood land values); LA Herald, Dec 30 1900 (Hollywood grove exchange listings); LA Herald, Jan 2 1898, Vol. 25, No. 94 (Lee A. McConnell & Co., 218 S. Broadway, “$600 per acre, lemons, bearing, Hollywood, on Sunset Boulevard” — McConnell series #1, 3.5 years post-survey); LA Herald, Feb 10 1901, Vol. XXVIII, No. 132 (McConnell, 145 S. Broadway, Hollywood and Suburban — McConnell series #2); LA Herald, Apr 28 1901, Vol. XXVIII, No. 210 (McConnell, 145 S. Broadway, “level as a floor... finest spot on earth... twelve years we have sold Hollywood land” — McConnell series #3, gem ad, primary citation anchor for floor language in real estate copy).

Nomadic era: Auburn Journal, Oct 13 1904 (Selig shot in Colorado); Colusa Daily Sun, Aug 24 1909 (farmer with rifle, Mount Shasta); Truckee Republican, Jan 26 1910 (fake Peary North Pole expedition, Donner Lake).

Node 2 baseline: LA Herald, Nov 8 1908 (Edendale drug store exchange, $6,000, want Oregon); LA Herald, Feb 21 1909 (Elysian Heights, $3,500, Edendale car line); LA Times, circa 1909 (building permit: Alessandro Street 1851, Selig Polyscope, one-story photographic studio, $3,977); San Jose Mercury News, Oct 30 1911 ($100/acre alfalfa, 3 days post-pivot).

Node 2 dissolution: LA Herald, Aug 7 1915 (sacrifice sale, 4 Edendale lots); LA Herald, Feb 9 1916 (wanted — Edendale or Hollywood, rent must be very reasonable); LA Herald, Aug 5 1919 (Selig "grand nabob," 8% grade comedy); LA Herald, Dec 23 1919 (rabbit hutches, $13.50/month).

Pivot day / Boggs: LA Herald, Oct 27 1911; Press Democrat, Oct 28 1911 (full account: $500 salary, Bosworth in room, Selig expansion conference).

Marysville Democrat: Jun 19 1911, reprinting LA Times (full text: $250,000, $2,000 stagecoach, Bosworth named, star system predicted).

Council hearing: LA Herald, Oct 25 and Nov 13 1916 ("Too important to be harassed away" · "half the renting houses vacant" · $350,000 Lasky · $15,000,000 industry).

Christie confession: Christie, Al. "What New Sites for Studios Mean to Hollywood." Los Angeles Examiner, 17 Feb. 1924. · "Nestor Company in Hollywood." Moving Picture World, vol. 10, no. 6, 11 Nov. 1911, p. 467.

DeMille / Lasky: DeMille, Cecil B. The Autobiography of Cecil B. DeMille. Prentice-Hall, 1959. · Eyman, Scott. Empire of Dreams. Simon & Schuster, 2010.

Babylon set: Photoplay Magazine, Aug. 1916 · Bitzer, G.W. Billy Bitzer: His Story. FSG, 1973 · Wanamaker,

Marc. Hollywood, 1900–1950. Arcadia Publishing, 2009.

Transit: Map of the City of Los Angeles Showing Railway Systems, 1906, Library of Congress / Travel and Hotel Bureau.

§X · Hollywoodland: LA Evening Express, Mar 31 1923; LA Examiner, Apr 27 1924; LA Herald, Jan 3 1927; Oakland Tribune, Sep 19 1932. Sign erected July 1923. Sign elevation ~1,750 ft per USGS topo; floor 356 ft per 1894 survey; vertical difference 1,394 ft.

Modern: MapCortex topographic layer (USGS/OpenStreetMap), March 2026. Post-1959 Glendale Freeway grading means modern Edendale data understates original canyon depth.

All newspaper sources via California Digital Newspaper Collection (CDNC) except where noted.